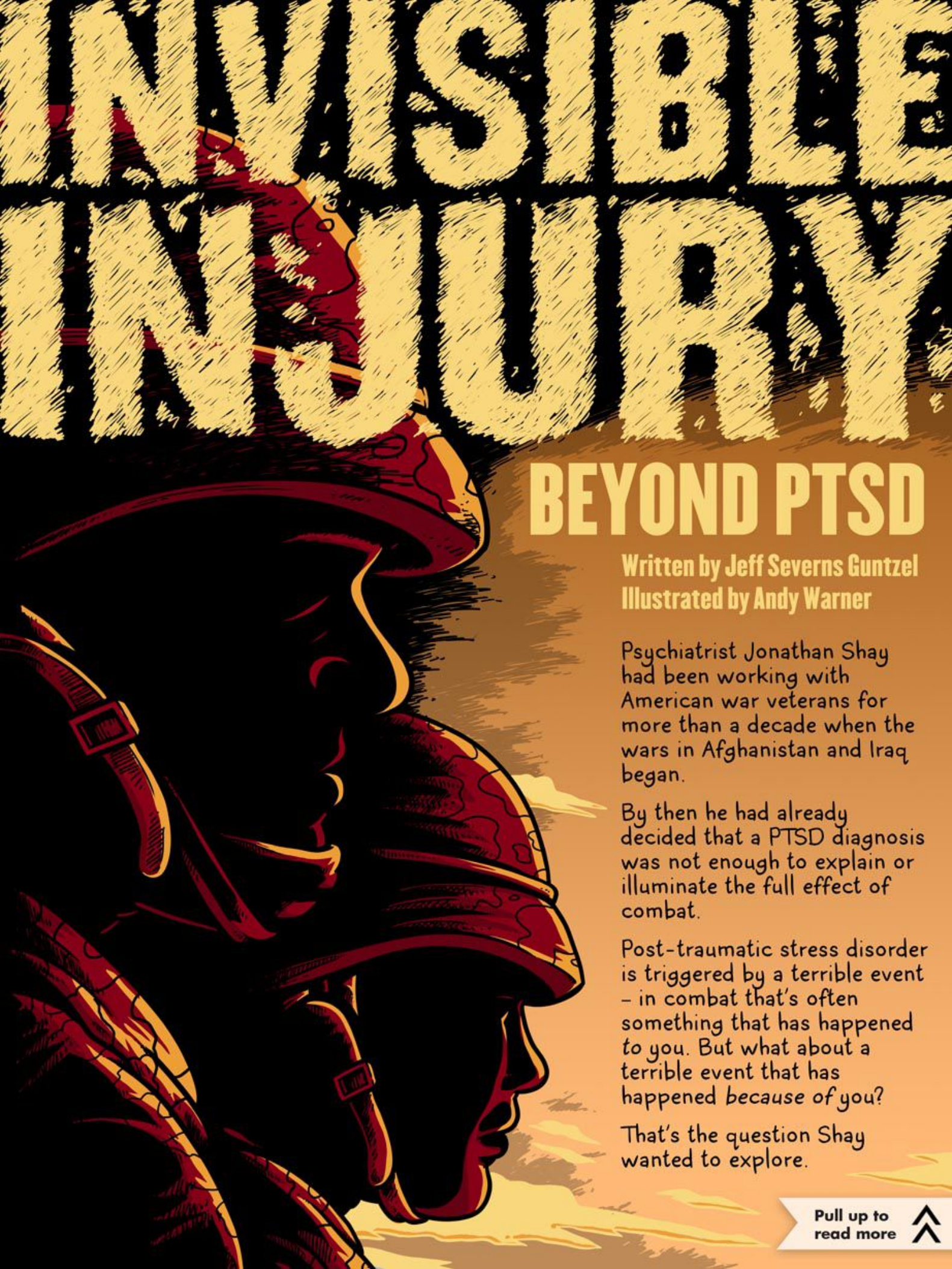


BEYOND PTSD

Written by Jeff Severns Guntzel
Illustrated by Andy Warner

Psychiatrist Jonathan Shay had been working with American war veterans for more than a decade when the wars in Afghanistan and Iraq began.

By then he had already decided that a PTSD diagnosis was not enough to explain or illuminate the full effect of combat.

Post-traumatic stress disorder is triggered by a terrible event – in combat that's often something that has happened *to* you. But what about a terrible event that has happened *because of* you?

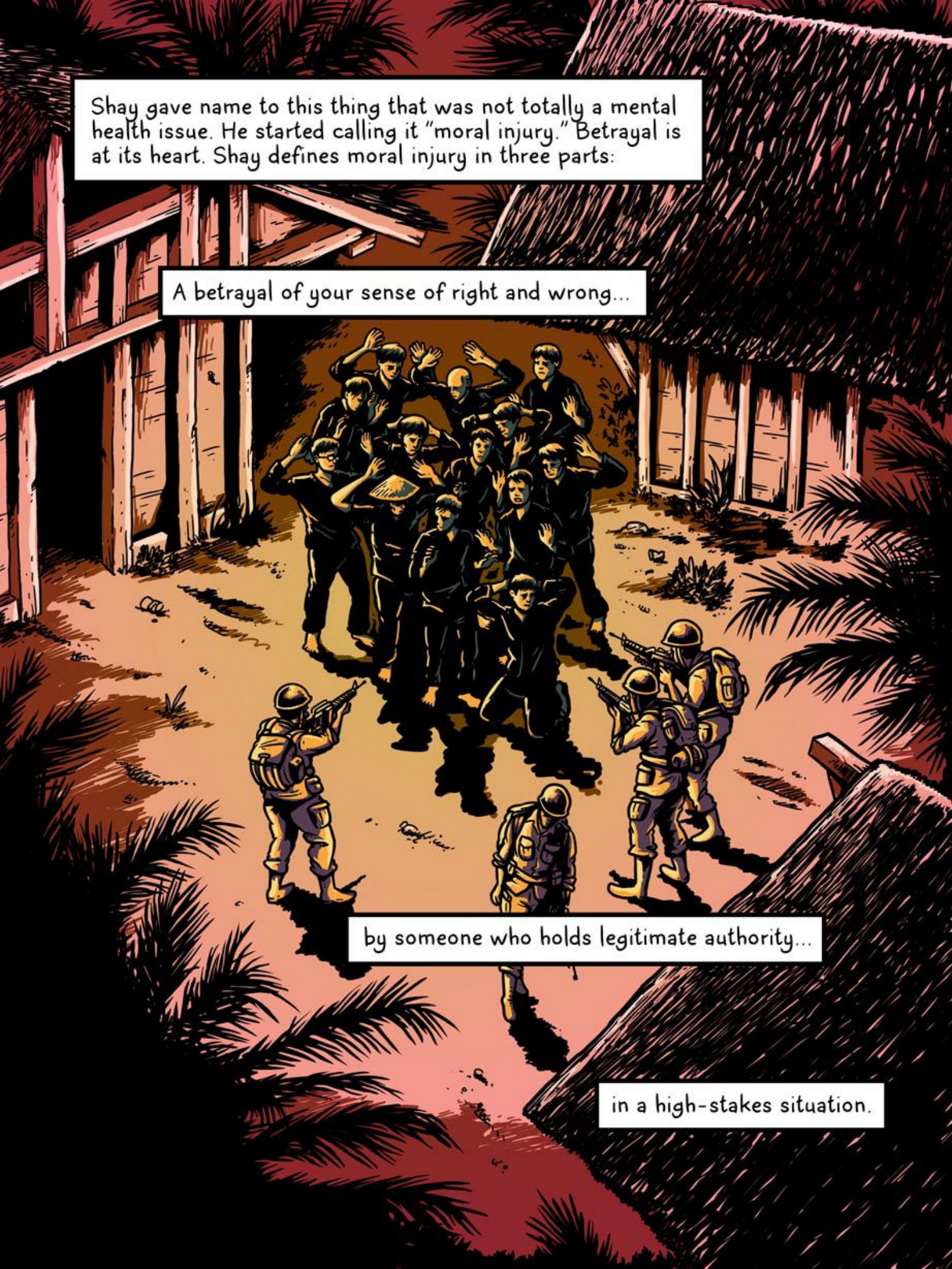
That's the question Shay wanted to explore.

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For years, Shay worked with Vietnam veterans in Boston.
One man had been an in-the-gutter drunk for many years.
It took time for the former Marine corporal to talk about the worst stuff he carried...
...but when he did, he spoke in the terms of his Irish Catholic upbringing:
I carried them into sin.


In Vietnam, the corporal and his three-man fire team had been put in charge of more than a dozen prisoners...
...who were disarmed and not resisting.
Their sergeant, leaving the scene, looked back and said:
We don't need no prisoners.
My patient took that as an order to kill them.
But his fellow Marines were extremely reluctant.
So he fired and egged them on.
BANG! BANG! BANG! BANG! BANG!
They killed all of the prisoners.


My response wasn't, 'Oh, you shouldn't feel guilty.'
It was to express my enormous respect.
Respect because his remorseful confession meant he had preserved a sense of right and wrong.
Your soul is still alive within you.
The question is: How can you work with this so it doesn't destroy your life and your family's life?
This was not totally a mental health issue - this was so clearly a religious issue, too.
I don't come from the Roman Catholic tradition, but I was able to talk about the sacrament of penance and of confession - not the chickenshit sins you confessed in parochial school.
It's about the real stuff: Murder, and a betrayal of good faith.


Shay gave name to this thing that was not totally a mental health issue. He started calling it "moral injury." Betrayal is at its heart. Shay defines moral injury in three parts:
A betrayal of your sense of right and wrong...
by someone who holds legitimate authority...
in a high-stakes situation.


There's also something Shay calls a shrinking of the moral horizon.
Say you're a well-meaning kid, newly enlisted and facing your first deployment. You're in it to fight the good fight.
Your moral horizon is like a big tent.
Inside is everybody you care about and feel responsible to.
All the people you're deploying with.
Friends and family
Maybe your fellow Americans.
Maybe even the people of Afghanistan or Iraq.

Then something happens.

The stakes are high, orders are given, you act,
and your sense of what's right is betrayed.


You blame your commanding officer. He's out of the tent. Your moral horizon is one person smaller.


You blame the locals and they are out of the tent. You are no longer accountable to them.

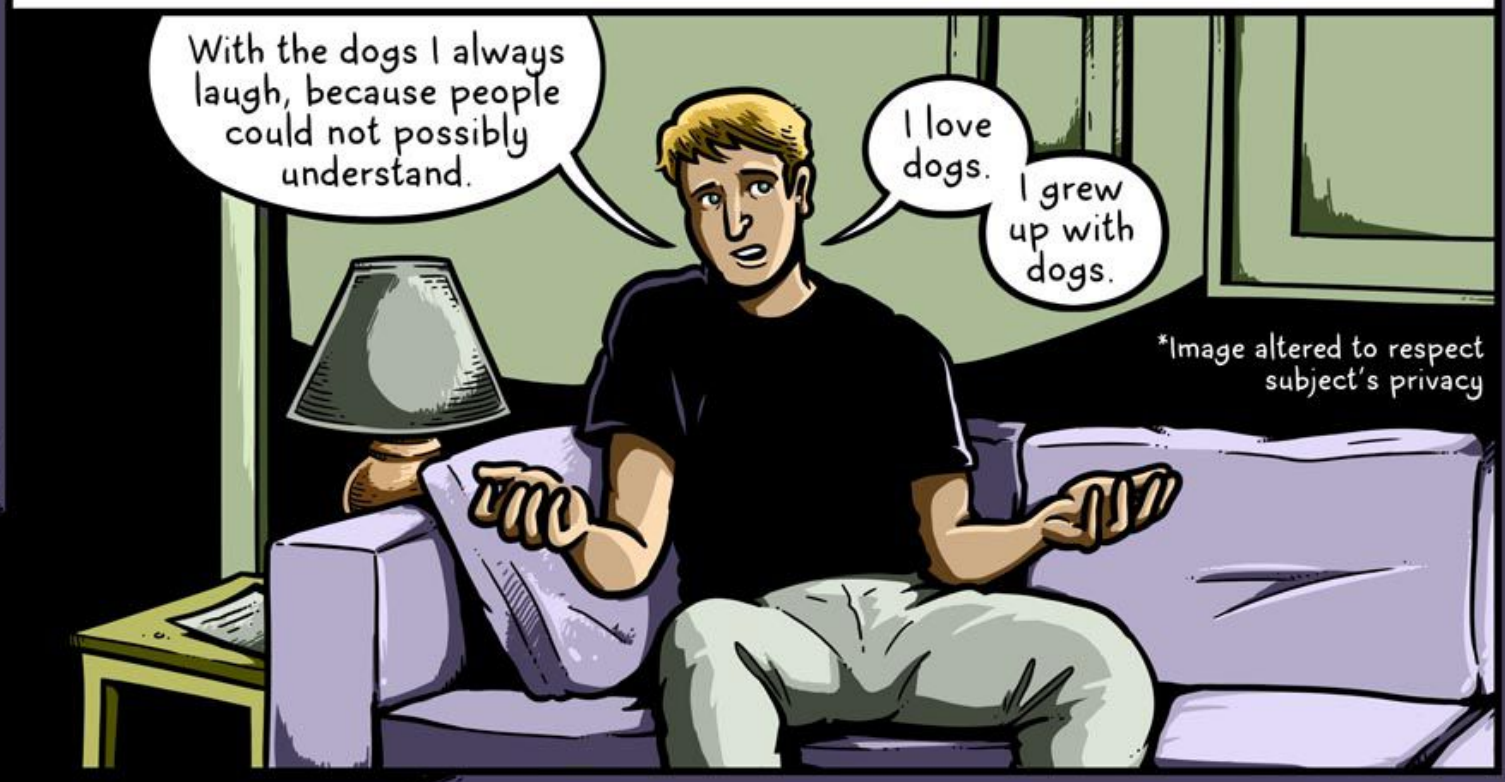

You blame the people who supported the war in the first place and they are out of the tent, too.



Pretty soon you're in that tent alone and all around you, every second of every day, is the war.

"Tom"* is an Army veteran who deployed twice to Iraq. He lives in the suburbs of Boston and asked that we not use his real name.

Tom tells a story of moral injury where nobody dies. It gets at another way of defining moral injury and where *you* stand in for the person in legitimate authority, betraying a sense of right and wrong.







One of our staff sergeants got bit early on and he had to have these rabies shots - like the old-school ones with the six-inch needles.

After that it was like a mandatory rule: *You will shoot every dog.*

So we were clearing this whole village, nobody getting shot or dying, but it was chaos. Things were burning, yadda, yadda...



We came to this last house and this dog was going crazy.





The dog started to shake so uncontrollably, I thought it was going to die of a heart attack.



Maybe I was too soft at the time, but I just had this feeling... Like, what are we *doing*?



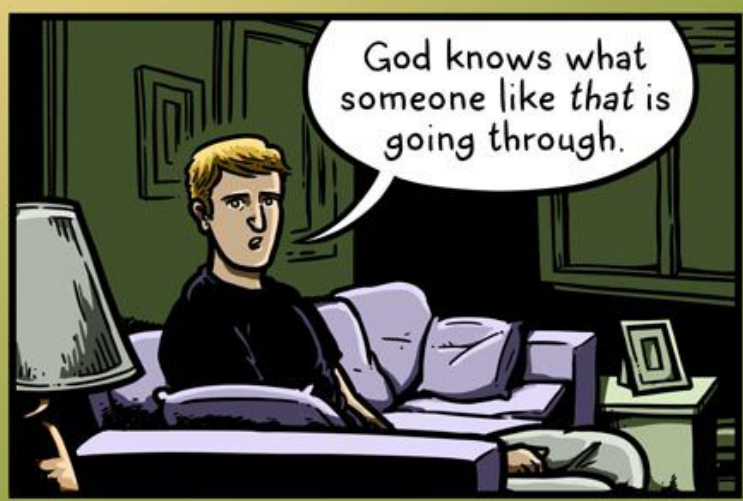
This dog is barking because a bunch of soldiers just went through its house and grabbed its owner and now they're breaking things.

What am I doing here?

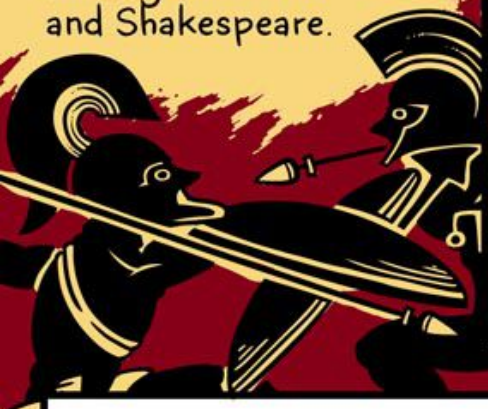


It was not a good feeling.





In his explorations of moral injury, Jonathan Shay has compared the modern moral injury experience to the literary work of Homer and Shakespeare.



Through his work with the VA Boston Healthcare System, clinical psychologist Brett Litz used scientific inquiry to build on Shay's literary and philosophical work.



He's partnered up with the Marine Corps, the Navy and the VA to track moral injury in Iraq and Afghanistan veterans.

The goal, Litz says, is to discover psychological, spiritual, social and biological consequences of moral injury. He's developed a questionnaire that can be used in any military or veteran context to evaluate the extent of service-related moral injury. Like Shay, Litz believes that moral injury accounts for some behaviors that PTSD alone can't explain. He has identified "three biggies" among them:

1: Self-harm

You feel unforgivable and, at a very deep level, that you deserve to suffer. You may abuse drugs or drive dangerously. You may not care whether you live or die.



2: Self-handicapping

You may feel guilty if you feel good, so you handicap yourself. You sabotage the situation.



3. Demoralization

There will be a small percentage of people who might feel as though they don't fit in. It might be because you've seen so much death and so much human evil that it's difficult for you to feel comfortable. So you shut down and withdraw.




The effort to quantify moral injury is still young, but we have stories to help us figure out what it is and what it is not.
In his work, Litz has studied how service members and veterans seeking help for PTSD answer this question: "What, currently, is most distressing and most haunting for you?"
Asking the question may not reveal anything about war that we don't already know. It is distressing.
It can haunt you.
But talking frankly with veterans about what distresses and haunts them helps researchers like Shay and Litz understand the shape of moral injury and just how common it really is.
Ultimately, the goal of this science based on stories, Litz says, is to find ways to help people to heal from their "uniquely toxic wounds."
That can mean the difference between isolation...
and understanding.
Between chaos...
and community.

ARE YOU A VETERAN?



Reporting for this piece was done by Martha Bebinger, Samara Freemark and Jeff Severns Guntzel. Illustration and layout by Andy Warner

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